Journal of English for Academic Purposes 58 (2022) 101120

Contents lists available at ScienceDirect

Journal of English for Academic Purposes

journal homepage: www.elsevier.com/locate/jeap

Exemplification in Chinese English-major MA students' and expert writers' academic writing: A local grammar based investigation

Hang Su [a,*], Yuqing Zhang [a], Meng Huat Chau [b]

[a] Sichuan International Studies University, China
[b] Universiti Malaya, Malaysia

ARTICLE INFO

Keywords:
Local grammar
Exemplification
Chinese English-major MA students
Expert writing

ABSTRACT

This study adopts a local grammar approach to investigate exemplification in Chinese English-major MA student writers' and expert writers' academic writing. Using corpora compiled of Chinese English-major MA students' degree dissertations and expert writers' published research articles in the field of Applied Linguistics as the data, the investigation shows that although the Chinese MA student writers used exemplification as frequently as expert writers to specify abstract superordinate categories, they underused exemplification with regard to aspects such as performative verbs, exemplificatory imperatives, and the strategy of exemplifying by citing relevant studies. The implications of local grammar based investigation into academic writing for EAP writing research and pedagogy are further discussed.

1. Introduction

English for Academic Purposes (EAP) writing research has traditionally focused on investigating lexicogrammatical features such as lexical bundles (e.g., Cortes, 2004; Hyland, 2008), signalling nouns (e.g., Flowerdew, 2006, 2010), and syntactic complexity (e.g., Lu, 2010; Ortega, 2015). While some studies have also considered discoursal features such as cohesion and coherence (e.g., Crossley, Kyle, & McNamara, 2016; Todd, Thienpermpool, & Keyuravong, 2004) and the interpersonal aspect of academic writing within the framework of metadiscourse (e.g., Hyland, 2004; Ädel, 2006), the pragmatic aspect seems to have been largely neglected in EAP writing research. This study attempts to bridge this gap by exploring English second language (hereafter L2) student writers' pragmatic performance of discourse acts, with the term 'discourse act' used as an equivalent of communicative or rhetorical functions such as giving examples, defining terminologies, and making comparison and contrast.

Specifically, the study focuses on the discourse act of exemplification. Following the tradition of research established in many studies comparing student and expert writers' practices (e.g., Ansarifar, Shahriari, & Pishghadam, 2018; Larsson, 2016), the current study compares the use of exemplification by one specific group of L2 student writers, i.e., Chinese English-major MA student writers, with that by expert writers in their published research articles in the field of Applied Linguistics. To that end, it draws on insights from local grammar research, as local grammars have been shown to be useful for quantifying reliably the realisations of discourse acts across contexts and as such facilitate contrastive investigation (Section 3). The study will not only further the discussion on the need to raise the pragmatic or rhetorical awareness of academic writers, especially L2 and novice academic writers, but also offer a viable

* Corresponding author. Centre for Foreign Languages and Literature, Sichuan International Studies University, 33 Zhuanzhi Road, Shapingba District, Chongqing, 400031, China.

E-mail addresses: suhangunique@hotmail.com (H. Su), zhangyuqing1201@outlook.com (Y. Zhang), chaumenghuat@um.edu.my (M.H. Chau).

https://doi.org/10.1016/j.jeap.2022.101120
Received 28 May 2021; Received in revised form 12 April 2022; Accepted 19 April 2022
Available online 6 May 2022
1475-1585/© 2022 Elsevier Ltd. All rights reserved.

method (i.e., local grammar) to explore their pragmatic performance of discourse acts in academic writing, thereby contributing to EAP writing research.

The remainder of the paper is organised into five sections. In Section 2 we discuss exemplification and highlight the importance of investigating exemplification in academic writing. In Section 3 we propose a local grammar approach to explore academic writers' pragmatic performance of discourse acts in the context of EAP. Section 4 introduces the corpora and the method used to retrieve the data. Section 5 presents the analyses, discusses the results, and considers the implications and applications of the (kind of) research reported in this paper for EAP writing research and pedagogy. Section 6 concludes the paper.

2. Exemplification in academic writing

Previous studies have observed that there are a number of discourse acts, that is, rhetorical or communicative functions, that are frequently performed in academic writing, and have also emphasised the importance of the teaching of these acts in academic contexts (e.g., Widdowson & Allen, 1985; Jordan, 1999 [1st ed. 1980]; Paquot, 2008). Paquot (2010, p. 83), for instance, identified twelve such acts or functions as exemplification (i.e., the act of giving examples), cause and effect (i.e., the act of explaining why things happen), and comparison and contrast (i.e., the act of comparing and contrasting). In addition to the aforementioned ones, Kirszner and Mandell (2017) and Fang (2021) further discussed many other such acts or writing skills as definition (i.e., the act of defining terms/concepts) and classification (i.e., the act of sorting items into categories). The present study focuses on exemplification which, according to Hyland (2007, p. 270), refers to "a communication process through which meaning is clarified or supported by a second unit which illustrates the first by citing an example". For our purpose we slightly modified Hyland's (2007) definition. We define exemplification as a discourse act performed by the writer him/herself to illustrate or support an argument, a viewpoint, an observation, etc., or to present subordinate categories or subtypes to clarify or specify abstract, superordinate ones, as illustrated in examples (1) and (2) respectively.

(1) This analytical framework has also been applied to other more specialised domains. For example, Cortes (2013) applies the lexical bundle framework to the study of university student writing in history.
(2) An example of this potential oversight is the lack of discussion by the researchers regarding notable disparities …

In example (1), the second sentence starting with Cortes (2013) *applies* … cites a relevant study to illustrate or support the argument (i.e., *the framework has been applied to other specialised domains*) presented in the preceding sentence, and in example (2), *the lack of discussion* … is a specific example that specifies *this potential oversight*.

The importance of focusing on exemplification can be seen on a number of grounds. First, exemplification is a frequently performed discourse act in academic writing across various disciplines. For example, Siepmann (2005) points out that exemplification is particularly prominent in humanities texts. Hyland (2007, p. 270) notes that exemplification is "a recurrent feature of academic writing and a central aspect of exposition, a part of the routine ways in which writers in all fields seek to make their ideas accessible and persuasive". Similarly, Paquot (2010) observes that presenting examples is much more frequent in academic texts than in other genres (e.g., conversation, fiction).

Next, a number of important functions of exemplification are evident in academic writing. For example, studies such as Coltier (1988, cited in Siepmann, 2005, p. 112) suggest that examples serve to support abstract knowledge and generate new knowledge. Hinkel (2004, p. 297) further points out that "providing contextually relevant examples and illustrations represents a reasonable and valid means of thesis support in explaining one's position on an issue". In a similar vein, Hyland (2007, p. 283) argues that offering examples can "make other channels of persuasion available to support the writer's argument, diluting unrelieved technical argument or flights of abstraction with specific, material description with which the reader can more immediately identify". In a nutshell, exemplification serves to provide additional information to clarify or specify relatively abstract concept or knowledge, to illustrate or support arguments or viewpoints and, ultimately, to ensure the persuasiveness and accessibility of an academic text (see also Hinkel, 2004; Hyland, 2007; Su & Zhang, 2020; Triki, 2021).

Despite the widespread employment and importance of exemplification in academic writing, studies have found that L2 or novice writers have difficulty using exemplification appropriately. For example, Hinkel (2004, p. 297) observes that "[a]lthough giving examples represents a prevalent explanatory and thesis support strategy in constructing persuasive text in English, teachers and researchers have found that college-level L2 writers rarely employ this strategy successfully and in accordance with the guidelines identified in L2 composition instruction". Siepmann (2005, p. 112) similarly argues that "it [exemplification] poses serious difficulties for L1 and L2 learners". Paquot's (2008) investigation further shows that English L2 writers' repertoire of exemplifying phraseologies is far more limited than that of their English L1 counterpart. In short, L2 writers have been reported to experience difficulty in performing exemplification appropriately, which is likely due to a perceived limited repertoire on their part in exemplifying phraseologies. Hence, a thorough investigation into exemplification in academic writing is itself a worthwhile undertaking in that it could help to systematically document and describe the lexicogrammatical resources that are available to perform exemplification. Findings from investigations of this kind could also usefully inform the teaching and learning of exemplification in EAP contexts (see also Oliveira & Brown, 2016; Su & Zhang, 2020; Zhang & Su, 2021).

Another reason for focusing on exemplification relates to the corpus methodology. Specifically, this is because exemplification has been shown to be typically signalled by a set of lexical markers. Hyland (2007), for instance, explores academic writers' use of exemplification across disciplines by examining several exemplificatory markers such as *for example*, *for instance*, and *such as*. In a similar vein, other studies such as Paquot (2008, 2010) and Su and Zhang (2020) also start with such exemplificatory markers.

Moreover, Triki (2021, p. 3) points out that using an explicit indicator when exemplifying is the norm to guarantee unambiguous meaning of exemplification. Since the current investigation uses corpus methods to investigate Chinese English-major MA student writers' use of exemplification in their academic writing, the observation that exemplification is typically signalled by lexical markers suggests that it is amenable to corpus search.

Notwithstanding its prominence in academic writing, exemplification has been largely neglected in EAP writing research (Siepmann, 2005). Only a few studies have investigated exemplification in academic discourse so far. These include Hyland (2007) who explored how professional academic writers use exemplification to construct and illustrate their arguments, and Su and Zhang (2020) who attempted to document the lexicogrammatical resources available to perform exemplification by analysing academic texts produced by expert writers. Another recent study is that of Triki (2021) who presented a cross-disciplinary investigation into exemplification across soft and hard disciplines. Nonetheless, investigation into exemplification in student or learner writing is even rarer. It seems, to date, that only Paquot (2008, 2010) has examined exemplification in English L2 learners' academic writing and found, not surprisingly, that learners have a relatively limited repertoire of phraseologies available to perform exemplification.

Moreover, previous studies normally investigate exemplification by examining the use of exemplificatory markers. That is, they tend to explore exemplification from a lexicogrammatical perspective. This area of research, however, has rarely been examined from a functional or discourse-semantic perspective. At the same time, it is worth mentioning that some recent EAP studies have attempted to analyse lexicogrammatical forms (e.g., lexical bundles, syntactically complex sentences) in terms of the rhetorical functions they realise (e.g., Cortes, 2013; Le & Harrington, 2015; Lu, Yoon, & Kisselev, 2021; Moreno & Swales, 2018). These studies have shown the importance of shifting the focus of examining lexicogrammatical features to a functional or discourse-semantic analysis of academic writing and further discussed the potential implications for EAP writing pedagogy. In particular, Lu, Casal, and Liu argue that,

> … systematic characterizations of the linguistic features associated with particular communicative functions may potentially deepen our understanding of disciplinary genre practices and provide insights and resources for EAP writing pedagogy.
> (Lu, Casal, & Liu, 2020, p. 1, p. 1)

In line with this body of research, the present study draws on a functional approach, i.e., local grammar (see Section 3), to investigate exemplification in Chinese English-major MA student writers' and expert writers' academic writing. It will be shown that local grammars allow us to explore the phraseological patternings of language use at the discourse-semantic level, which in turn offers some insights for future investigation into academic writers' performance of other discourse acts of importance in EAP writing research.

3. A local grammar approach to investigating discourse acts in academic writing

We illustrate our approach to investigating student writers' pragmatic performance of discourse acts by comparing their use of exemplification with that of expert writers (see Section 4 for more discussion about the data). As will be seen, the current investigation involves the quantification of the realisations of a given discourse act. To that end, we further draw on insights from local grammar research: a functional approach to linguistic analysis and explanation that seeks to account for one meaning or function only (Hunston, 2002a). One of the defining features that distinguish local grammars from general grammars is that they use functionally transparent and context-specific terminologies to analyse instances realising the target discourse or communicative act (see Barnbrook and Sinclair (2001) and Su et al. (2018) for more discussion about local grammars and general grammars). In other words, local grammars attempt to account for the relationship between syntactic units by using functional terms rather than by using grammatical ones such as Subject, Object etc. For the purpose of illustration, Table 1 presents examples of local grammar analyses of exemplification.

In the example … *topics impose the need for different communicative skills. For example, 'Pumps' is an ideal topic for teaching static and dynamic description* …, the discourse-semantic relationship between the two clauses is one of exemplification, with the second clause illustrating the preceding one. Thus, the semantics of the first clause is the thing being exemplified and that of the second is a specific example of the thing being exemplified; the marker *for example* indicates that the act of exemplifying is being performed. From the perspective of local grammars, we can use terminologies such as 'Exemplified', 'Indicator', and 'Exemplification-SC' to account for the relationship between these syntactic units. The point, then, is that each syntactic unit which has a pragmatic meaning is analysed using a functional terminology that is directly related to its discoursal or pragmatic function in local grammar analysis. In the meantime, it

Table 1
Local grammar analyses of exemplification (adapted from Su, Zhang, & Lu, 2021).

Exemplified	Indicator	Exemplification-SC[a]
… topics impose the need for different communicative skills	*For example*	*'Pumps' is an ideal topic for teaching static and dynamic description …*
Exemplified	Indicator	Exemplification-RS
Outside the USA, there are also some studies on LI retention	*(for example*	*Hill and Hill 1977 on Aztec in Mexico; Campbell 1980 on Italian in Australia)*

Exemplified	Hinge	Indicator	Exemplification-SC
… reporting verbs were taken from journals in diverse fields	*(including*	*for example*	*Applied Linguistics, Geology, Public Administration, Engineering)*

[a] Exemplification-SC is the short form of Exemplification-Subcategory, which means that the act of exemplifying is realised by presenting subcategories. Exemplification-RS stands for Exemplification-Relevant study, which means that the act of exemplifying is realised by citing relevant studies (see Section 5 for more discussion about the terminologies).

should also be noted that the syntactic unit realising a given functional terminology may either be nominal or verbal phrase(s) or clause (s), as seen in Table 1.

While Table 1 illustrates the mapping of functional-pragmatic terms onto corresponding syntactic units, it also points to a challenging issue involved in local grammar research, which relates to the identification of a set of appropriate functional-pragmatic terminologies for the subsequent local grammar analyses. It is challenging because the identification of such terminologies requires the analyst to interpret the discourse-semantic relations between the syntactic units of the target instances. To overcome this challenge, Su (2020a) suggests two guiding principles. One is termed the Principle of Transparency, meaning that the terminologies should be proposed within the specific context of the target pragmatic or discourse act and that the terminologies should explicitly reflect the discourse function of the syntactic unit being analysed. The other is termed the Principle of Economy, which requires the analyst to strike a balance between the specificity and the number of the terminologies identified. The two principles would, arguably, be useful to guide the identification of terminologies for local grammar research (see Su (2020a) for more discussion).

Currently, local grammars have been employed to account for discourse or communicative acts such as evaluation (Hunston & Sinclair, 2000; Hunston & Su, 2019), definition (Barnbrook, 2002), disclaiming (Cheng & Ching, 2018), and exemplification (Su & Zhang, 2020). These studies show that local grammars can provide a more systematic and specialised description of the target discourse or communicative act, thereby contributing to the description of language use in general (see also Bednarek, 2008; Butler, 2004; Hunston & Sinclair, 2000; Su, 2017; Su & Wei, 2018). Furthermore, the resulting local grammar descriptions are more informative for language teaching, because it would be more useful to know an element in terms of its discoursal or communicative function than in grammatical ones (see also Hunston, 2002b, p. 157). Indeed, recent research has further discussed the pedagogical implications and applications of local grammar research, such as raising language learners' awareness of the patterned nature of language in use and that such research can be used to inform the design of English teaching materials (e.g., Hunston & Su, 2019; Su, 2020b; Su & Zhang, 2020; Zhang & Su, 2021).

Another notable strength of using a local grammar approach to describe language use, which is of most relevance to the present study, is that the resulting local grammar descriptions offer a way to quantify the realisations of a given discourse act. This is based on the observation that once the (local) grammar of a given discourse act is developed, realisations of that discourse act can be identified in a corpus and, accordingly, the frequency of instances realising a particular local grammar pattern can be calculated (Hunston, 2002a, pp. 180–181). This has been demonstrated by, for example, Bednarek (2007) who used a local grammar approach to compare evaluative language used in broadsheet and tabloid, and found that differences between them are more likely to be revealed by the frequency of evaluative patterns than the function of these patterns. Other studies which further explored the potential of local grammars in quantifying the realisations of a given pragmatic or discourse act include Su (2020a, 2021). Specifically, Su (2020a, 2021), examining the realisations of the speech act of apology, observed that instances containing the same illocutionary force indicating devices (hereafter IFID) may realise different discourse-semantic patterns and that different IFIDs may realise the same pattern. This in turn suggests that simply counting the occurrences of given lexical items or IFIDs may not be able to quantify reliably the ways in which a given speech act is performed. Su (2020a, 2021) therefore proposes and demonstrates a local grammar approach to contrastive speech act studies.

In the case of discourse acts in academic writing, Su et al. (2021) examined exemplification and found that the same exemplificatory marker, like the same IFID in speech act studies, may realise different discourse-semantic patterns and that one same pattern may be realised by different markers. The upshot of the discussion, then, is that simply counting the lexicogrammatical markers might not be a reliable way to quantify how exemplification, and by extension other discourse acts, is used by different groups of writers. The local grammar approach, on the other hand, may be able to quantify more reliably the realisations of a given discourse act, because it captures the regularities of language use at both the lexicogrammatical and discourse-semantic levels. Seen in this light, local grammars could be a useful approach for contrastive discourse studies in general. In the present study we thus employ the local grammar approach to compare Chinese English-major MA student writers' use of exemplification with that of expert writers, aiming to explore their performance of exemplification in academic writing. This comparison is of course not without limitations, which will be further discussed later when we consider the implications of the current study for EAP writing research and pedagogy.

4. Corpora and data retrieval

For the current investigation, two corpora were compiled of academic texts in the field of Applied Linguistics. Of the two corpora one was compiled of Chinese English-major MA students' degree dissertations (hereafter CEMAD) and the other of published research articles by expert writers (hereafter CORA). The MA dissertations were all from the Applied Linguistics programme of universities in mainland China. They were collected partly because dissertations in this MA programme were required to be written in English (note that this requirement does not apply to other MA programmes at Chinese universities) and partly because writers in this discipline have been shown to employ relatively more exemplificatory resources than writers of other disciplines (Hyland, 2007). In addition, we focus on the genre of MA dissertations because it is, as Hyland (2004, p. 134) notes, "a high stakes genre at the summit of a student's academic accomplishment". The MA dissertations would thus make rich data for the current investigation. Lastly, it is important to mention that Chinese MA students' dissertations were uploaded to CNKI (China National Knowledge Infrastructure) after their graduation, and are then made available to all subscribing universities. This has facilitated the compilation of the first corpus of this study.

The other corpus is compiled from research articles published in *Applied Linguistics* (https://academic.oup.com/applij/). Published research articles were used as reference because they "are commonly recognised as the model of academic writing" (Alangari, Jaworska, & Laws, 2020, p. 4) and "represents the norm that advanced learner writers try to reach and their teachers try to promote"

Table 2
Meta-information of the two corpora.

Corpora	No. of texts	No. of tokens	Average length
CORA	330	4,213,509	12,768.21
CEMAD	162	3,558,276	21,964.67

(Ädel, 2006, p. 207). Moreover, *Applied Linguistics* has a relatively long history of publication (with the first issue published in 1980), covers a broad range of topics in Applied Linguistics, and is currently ranked as the top 1 journal in the category of Linguistics; these properties ensure that the research articles collected would be highly representative of advanced academic writing in the field. At this point, it should be mentioned that the English L1 status of the authors in the sampling process was not considered, because all published articles have undergone rigorous peer review and careful editorial processing after acceptance. This also means that we ignored the linguacultural backgrounds of the authors and just viewed the corpus as representing expert performance of academic writing in Linguistics.

Table 2 provides the meta-information of the two corpora.

The two corpora were uploaded to Sketch Engine (https://app.sketchengine.eu/; Kilgarriff, Rychly, Smrz, & Tugwell, 2004) for data retrieval. As noted earlier, exemplification is typically signalled by a set of lexical markers. Accordingly, drawing on insights from previous studies, we identified eight markers and used them to search for instances of exemplification in our corpora (Table 3). As shown in Triki (2021), nearly 90% of instances of exemplification would co-occur with one of these markers. We are thus confident that searching these markers could yield a high hit rate of exemplification in a corpus, while in the meantime we acknowledge that a few instances of exemplification which do not co-occur with these markers have been left undetected.

A glimpse at Table 3 suggests that, overall, expert writers used more exemplificatory markers than Chinese English-major MA student writers did (2363.59 vs. 1947.02) and that the difference is statistically significant (LL = 155.15, $p < .0001$). With regard to individual markers, it is observed that while the two groups of writers' use of *for example* is of similar frequency, Chinese English-major MA student writers used *for instance* significantly more frequently (LL = 18.23, $p < .0001$). The reason for this may be that,

> … instruction is most likely responsible for the massive overuse of *for instance* in EFL students. *For example* and *for instance* are often taught as two synonyms and as a result, learners use them interchangeably. Learners presumably write *for instance* instead of *for example* when they have already used *for example* in their essay and want to change for the sake of variety.
>
> (Paquot, 2008, p. 110, p. 110)

It is also interesting to mention that Chinese English-major MA student writers used e.g. significantly less frequently but used *such as* significantly more frequently when performing exemplification. Additionally, the student writers under examination also used the performative verbs *exemplify* and *illustrate* less frequently, although only the difference in the use of *exemplify* is significant (LL = 16.69, $p < .0001$).

Nevertheless, just looking at the occurrences of these markers may not allow us to draw a full picture of how exemplification was used respectively by Chinese English-major MA student writers and expert writers. To remedy this problem, below we present a discourse-semantic analysis of their uses of exemplification from the perspective of local grammars and discuss the results and implications.

Table 3
Exemplificatory markers and their frequency in the two corpora.

Corpora / Markers	CORA		CEMAD		LL[b]	LR[c]
	Raw	Normed[a]	Raw	Normed		
for example	2363	560.82	1958	550.27	0.39	0.03
for instance	517	122.7	566	159.07	18.23**	−0.37
e.g.	3142	745.7	683	191.95	1324.82**	1.96
such as	2716	644.59	2903	815.84	77.91**	−0.34
an example of	170	40.35	64	17.99	33.56**	1.17
an instance of	36	8.54	12	3.37	8.84	1.34
exemplify	130	30.85	59	16.58	16.69**	0.90
illustrate	885	210.04	683	191.95	3.14	0.13
Total	**9959**	**2363.59**	**6928**	**1947.02**	**155.15****	**0.28**

[a] This refers to 'normalised frequency' which in the present study is normalised per million words.
[b] LL = log likelihood ratio; ** denotes $p < .0001$; * denotes $p < .001$.
[c] LR denotes log ratio or the binary log of the ratio of relative frequencies, and was used in the present study to measure the effect size (Hardie, 2014).

5. Data analyses, results, and discussion

As discussed in Section 3, local grammars use functional terminologies to analyse corresponding syntactic units. The identification of a set of appropriate terminologies is thus crucial. For our purpose we adapted the terminologies used in Su et al. (2021), as they have been shown to be useful for a local grammar analysis of exemplification. These terminologies are listed and explained in Table 4.

Because of space constraints and also given that previous studies have provided a good treatment and discussion of the local grammar analyses of exemplification (e.g., Su et al., 2021; Su & Zhang, 2020), we will not discuss the analyses any further, but only present some examples to illustrate how we performed the analyses in Table 5.

Our analyses identified 39 local grammar patterns in the two corpora. To avoid untypical uses, our discussion focuses on those patterns which have more than 10 occurrences in either corpus, whereas the other relatively infrequent patterns are listed in the Appendix. An overview of these patterns, with an example given of each, is presented in Table 6.

Table 7 gives an overview of the distribution of these patterns across the two corpora, providing the quantitative information for the subsequent discussion.

Based on the analyses, some observations can be tentatively drawn. First, as with the analysis of exemplificatory markers in Section 4, the local grammar analyses confirm that, overall, expert writers performed the act of exemplifying more frequently than Chinese English-major MA student writers did (2265.57 vs. 1827.57) and that the difference between the two groups of writers was significant (LL = 180.64, $p < .0001$). We further compared the means across CORA (mean = 119.24, standard deviation = 323.23) and CEMAD (mean = 96.19, standard deviation = 347.14) in terms of the local grammar patterns, and the results of non-parametric T-test (Mann-Whitney) showed that there were statistically significant differences between the two groups of writers' use of exemplification ($p = .025 < 0.05$). One explanation might be that the student writers were not fully aware of the importance of the use of exemplifications in academic writing, or that they were not familiar with the strategies to perform exemplification in academic writing. Either way, this points to the need for more explicit teaching of exemplification as well as other discourse acts in EAP writing pedagogy, as will be discussed in greater detail later.

Second, the most frequent pattern for both the expert and Chinese English-major MA student writers is PA 1 (Exemplified – Indicator – Exemplification-SC). In this pattern, writers provide subcategories to illustrate a superordinate category, making the general more specific (e.g., *the traditional methods such as teachers' instruction, classroom questions, and layout of homework* …). However, the statistics shows that the student writers used (only) this pattern significantly more frequently than expert writers (LL = 16.10, $p < .0001$). One possible explanation about this finding, together with the observation that the student writers underused the majority of other patterns identified in the study, is as reported in previous research that student writers had a relatively limited repertoire of exemplifying phraseologies and, consequently, relied heavily upon and overused those highly frequent ones (Paquot, 2008). This can be interpreted as mainly that expert writers have greater experience than student writers in using a wide range of exemplifying patterns.

An alternative interpretation of the overuse of PA 1 relates to language transfer (see also De Cock, 2003; Paquot, 2008). That is, because the typical sequence of exemplification in Chinese is also the one in which a writer presents the Exemplified, then Indicator,

Table 4
Terminologies for analysing exemplification (adapted from Su et al., 2021).

Terminology	Explanation	Example
Exemplified	The argument, viewpoint or superordinate category that is being illustrated or specified.	*There are various units of meter, or patterns, that a poet is likely to use,* such as iambs, trochees, spondees …
Exemplification-RS	One or more existing relevant studies that were used to specify or illustrate an argument or viewpoint.	… actually involves complex mechanics. *Schiffrin (1987: 24-8),* for example, proposes a five-plane model which …
Exemplification-SC	One or more subordinate categories that were used to specify a superordinate or abstract one.	The illocutionary act, i.e., the speaker's intention realised in producing an utterance, e.g., *request, compliment …*
Indicator	Exemplificatory markers signalling the act of exemplifying.	… overshadowed by issues *such as* subject matter learning, personal …
Initiator	Elements that introduce or initiate the act of exemplifying.	*We did not*, for example, search just for words and phrases related to …
Researcher	The person who performs the act of exemplifying.	*I* will illustrate with examples how each strategy is employed.
Hinge	Elements that link different parts.	The *haka* is an example of a ritualized …
Supporting statement	Elements that provide additional information to clarify or support an argument, viewpoint, or a category	Similar findings were reported by some other SLA researchers. Ranta (2002), for instance, *revealed that 'good language …*

Table 5
Examples of local grammar analyses of Exemplification.

Exemplification-SC	Hinge	Indicator	Exemplified
Fig. 2	*Is*	*an example of*	*a picture used for the gapless RC*
Exemplified	Hinge	Indicator	Exemplification-SC
Some of these bundles	*Are*	*illustrated*	*in the context in Extracts 8 and 9*
Researcher	Indicator	Exemplified	Exemplification-SC
We	*Illustrate*	*these issues*	*with two examples*
Exemplified	Exemplification-RS	Indicator	Supporting statement
… *not always the case that 'more is better'.*	*Sanell (2007)*	for instance	shows that Swedish learners of French as a foreign …

Table 6
An overview of the local grammar patterns identified in the two corpora.

No.	Pattern				
PA 1	**Exemplified** *… different kinds of love*	**Indicator** *such as*	**Exemplification-SC** *"family love", "friendship love", "love between couples" …*		
PA 2	**Exemplified** *Many language socialization studies therefore adopt an ethnographic approach*	**Indicator** (e.g.	**Exemplification-RS** DuFon 1999*)*.		
PA 3	**Exemplification-SC** *The following examples*	**Indicator** *Illustrate*	**Exemplified** *the semantic differences in the choice of research act RVs between Chinese writers and native writers.*		
PA 4	**Exemplified** *The composition of the subjects*	**Hinge** *is*	**Indicator** *illustrated*	**Exemplification-SC** *in Table 5 below.*	
PA 5	**Exemplified** *Some of these are created by traditional affixes.*	**Exemplification-SC** *Deshopper,*	**Indicator** *for example,*	**Supporting statement** *is derived by adding prefix de-(negative) to the root shopper …*	
PA 6	**Exemplified** *The use of conversational data from radio programmes*	**Hinge** *is well*	**Indicator** *illustrated*	**Exemplification-RS** *in Drew and Heritage (1992).*	
PA 7	**Exemplified** *Some other people define writing from different perspectives.*	**Indicator** *For instance,*	**Exemplification-RS** *John F. Lyons (1999)*	**Supporting statement** *thinks that writing is as an art and …*	
PA 8	**Exemplified** *This negotiation process actually involves complex mechanics.*	**Exemplification-RS** *Schiffrin (1987: 24-8)*	**Indicator** *for example,*	**Supporting statement** *proposes a five-plane model which involves …*	
PA 9	**Initiator** *Take*	**Indicator** *for example,*	**Exemplification-SC** *the proposition, "This stove is black."*		
PA10	**Exemplification-SC** *The following examples*	**Hinge** *may serve to*	**Indicator** *illustrate*	**Exemplified** *some differences between optional complements and peripheral elements in the field of adjectives.*	
PA11	**Exemplified** *Consequently, there are lots of fields to be discovered,*	**Exemplification-SC** *parental praising in Chinese families,*	**Indicator** *for example.*		
PA12	**Initiator** *To*	**Indicator** *illustrate*	**Exemplified** *how this might affect L2 pronunciation,*	**Exemplification-SC** *let us consider the learning of …*	
PA13	**Indicator** *An example of*	**Exemplified** *high–level evaluation*	**Hinge** *can be found*	**Exemplification-SC** *in turn 48 in Table 3.*	
PA14	**Indicator** *As illustrated*	**Exemplification-SC** *in Figure 1,*	**Exemplified** *each picture contains two animate agents, one of which corresponds to the subject of the matrix clause.*		
PA15	**Researcher** *We*	**Indicator** *will illustrate*	**Exemplified** *the above assertions*	**Exemplification-SC** *through a contrastive analysis of microgenesis instances.*	
PA16	**Initiator** *As*	**Exemplification-SC** Table 1	**Indicator** *illustrates*	**Exemplified** *the abstract nouns in the four categories differ in terms of their use …*	
PA17	**Researcher** *I*	**Hinge** *use*	**Exemplification-SC** *the first two interactions*	**Indicator** *to illustrate*	**Exemplified** *contingency in LS …*
PA18	**Exemplification-RS** *Pellettieri's research (1999)*	**Indicator** *illustrates*	**Exemplified** *that the majority of negotiations are triggered by …*		
PA19	**Exemplified** *Move 2 Step B would be used frequently to open the chapter*	**Hinge** *(see*	**Exemplification-SC** *the second sample above,*	**Indicator** *for example).*	

and finally the Exemplification (i.e., PA 1), the observation that PA 1 was most frequently used by Chinese English-major MA student writers may be accounted for by the fact that there is direct counterpart of the sequence in the two languages, thus resulting in positive transfer in language use (this explanation could also apply to other patterns such as PA 7 'Exemplified – Indicator – Exemplification-RS – Supporting statement'). At the same time, there was also negative transfer. For example, the reason why the student writers underused patterns in which the Indicator occurs at the end of a sentence (e.g., PA 11 'Exemplified – Exemplification-SC – Indicator') may be that in Chinese the Indicator rarely occurs at the final position of a sentence; and the reason why the students writers used much less frequently exemplificatory imperatives (e.g., PA 9 'Initiator – Indicator – Exemplification-SC') and other patterns with Initiator (e.g., PA 16 'Initiator – Exemplification-SC – Indicator – Exemplified') is likely that there is no direct counterpart of such realisations for exemplification in Chinese. In consequence, the student writers may feel less certain about using such ways to perform the act of exemplifying.

Third, the observation is worth discussing that student writers used far less frequently PA 2, the other formulaic pattern of exemplification, than expert writers did. As shown in Table 7, PA 2 is five times as frequent in CORA as in CEMAD. Our data analyses

Table 7
Distribution of the local grammar patterns across the two corpora.

No.	CORA		CEMAD		LL	LR
	Raw	Normed	Raw	Normed		
PA 1	5968	1416.40	5434	1527.14	16.10**	−0.11
PA 2	1436	340.81	233	65.48	772.93**	2.38
PA 3	374	88.76	142	39.91	72.61**	1.15
PA 4	330	78.32	192	53.96	17.32**	0.54
PA 5	284	67.40	112	31.48	51.01**	1.10
PA 6	221	52.45	4	1.12	236.68**	5.55
PA 7	205	48.65	152	42.72	1.49	0.19
PA 8	175	41.53	9	2.53	156.46**	4.04
PA 9	167	39.63	25	7.03	95.01**	2.49
PA 10	129	30.62	112	31.48	0.05	−0.04
PA 11	58	13.77	10	2.81	29.85**	2.29
PA 12	40	9.49	17	4.78	6.07	0.99
PA 13	36	8.54	8	2.25	14.85*	1.92
PA 14	31	7.36	27	7.59	0.01	−0.04
PA 15	23	5.46	10	2.81	3.30	0.96
PA 16	23	5.46	4	1.12	11.76*	2.29
PA 17	18	4.27	10	2.81	1.17	0.60
PA 18	15	3.56	0	0.00	18.37**	/
PA 19	13	3.09	2	0.56	7.26	2.46
Total	**9546**	**2265.57**	**6503**	**1827.57**	**180.64****	**0.31**

suggest that this pattern is usually realised by instances co-occurring with *e.g.* and serves the function of citing relevant studies to support the argument or viewpoint presented in the preceding clause, as in *Formulaic language has been defined in a number of ways (e.g., Wray 2002; 2008*). As this is a strategy that writers of published research articles normally use to make their argument more convincing and persuasive, the much higher frequency of PA 2 in CORA might be a consequence of a professional or generic style which requires the use of the pattern a lot. From the Chinese English-major student writers' perspective, one additional reason for this may be that the appropriate use of *e.g.* has not been well taught in the classroom and, consequently, resulting in their less frequent use of *e.g.* (see Table 3) and PA 2. This points to the need to adequately describe the context in which *e.g.* can be used and to teach student writers the important functions *e.g.* and the associated local grammar pattern can play in academic writing.

A fourth observation is concerned with the use of performative verbs *exemplify* and *illustrate*. Paquot (2008) found that English L2 learners tended to underuse *exemplify*, whereas they underused *illustrate* in the passive voice but overused it in the active alternative. In our analysis, performative verbs usually occur in Patterns 3 (Exemplification-SC – Indicator – Exemplified) and 4 (Exemplification-SC – Hinge – Indicator – Exemplified) which, as shown in Table 7, were both used significantly less frequently by the Chinese English-major MA student writers. This may suggest that the student writers were not familiar enough with the use of performative verbs when exemplifying.

Fifth, as discussed in Su et al. (2021), one can exemplify by either presenting subcategories or by citing relevant studies, each of which has different functions: we normally present subcategories to illustrate or specify abstract concepts or superordinate categories, and we cite relevant studies to illustrate or support our argument or viewpoint. It is therefore interesting to compare how the expert and student writers would use these two general strategies in their academic writing respectively. To that end, we examined the distribution of those patterns with the label Exemplification-SC and Exemplification-RS across the two corpora. The results are presented in Table 8.

This examination shows that presenting subcategories or subtypes to specify those abstract superordinate categories or types is, on the one hand, the primary function of giving examples, which applies to both corpora. This is consistent with Hyland's (2007, p. 279) finding that the overwhelming majority of cases of exemplification is where a writer offers an instance of a general category. On the other hand, the analysis shows that Chinese English-major MA student writers used significantly less frequently relevant studies to support or illustrate their argument or viewpoint than expert writers did (LL = 960.17, $p < .0001$). The reasons for this may be partly attributed to the fact that the student writers had not considered a sufficient number of relevant studies in their field, or that the strategy of exemplification by citing relevant studies is something relatively foreign or unfamiliar to them.

To recapitulate, our findings show that although Chinese English-major MA student writers used exemplification as nearly frequently as the expert writers to specify abstract superordinate categories, they underused exemplification in their academic writing with regard to aspects such as performative verbs, exemplificatory imperatives, and the strategy of exemplifying by citing relevant

Table 8
Distribution of patterns with Exemplification-SC and those with Exemplification-RS across the two corpora.

	CORA		CEMAD		LL	LR
	Raw	Normed	Raw	Normed		
Patterns with Exemplification-SC	7494	1778.57	6105	1715.73	4.36	0.05
Patterns with Exemplification-RS	2052	487.00	398	111.85	960.17**	2.12

studies. Their preference to use those more frequent or typical patterns may be due to their apparent limited repertoire of exemplifying phraseology or, alternatively, to their less familiarity with the use of those less frequent or typical patterns when performing exemplifications. Either possibility might be accounted for by their relative communicative experience in using those exemplifications in comparison with that of expert writers (Ellis & Wulff, 2020).

The findings of our research could have potential implications for both EAP writing research and pedagogy. As discussed above, Chinese English-major MA student writers' use of exemplification differs significantly from that of expert writers and they underused most of the exemplificatory markers and the associated local grammar patterns. Since it is unclear whether these observations may also hold true for student writers' of other linguacultural backgrounds and, more importantly, whether student writers' pragmatic performance of other discourse acts may show a similar pattern, we suggest that these would be directions that are worthy of future investigation in EAP writing research. More importantly, if similar findings were reported in future research, one implication would be that explicit teaching of discourse acts will be an essential component of EAP writing pedagogy. Hence, we further discuss briefly the pedagogical implications of the kind of research reported in the present study.

It should be noted that the teaching of discourse or communicative acts has also been emphasised in many other studies or academic writing textbooks (e.g., Widdowson & Allen, 1985; Jordan, 1999 [1st ed. 1980]; Kirszner & Mandell, 2017; Fang, 2021). We, however, propose a different approach, i.e., local grammar, to researching and teaching such discourse or communicative acts. Specifically, our argument is that findings of local grammar research can usefully inform the development of pedagogical materials that could facilitate the teaching of discourse acts in EAP contexts. On the one hand, this is based on the observation that local grammar based investigation into student writers' performance of discourse acts reveals the problems or difficulties they have when performing such discourse acts in academic writing. On the other hand, local grammars document systematically the lexicogrammatical realisations, paired with the associated local grammar patterns, of a specific discourse act, offering an inventory of the strategies available to perform that discourse act (as shown in Tables 3 and 6). This inventory can then be incorporated into EAP teaching materials, as discussed in Su and Zhang (2020). Such materials can not only make both the linguistic forms and their communicative function as obvious as possible (Widdowson & Allen, 1985), but also can be tailored to student writers' needs (i.e., what problems or difficulties they have performing appropriately a given discourse act), thereby facilitating the teaching of discourse acts in EAP contexts. Finally, as discourse acts have been shown to be common and crucial, to varying degrees, in all disciplinary academic writing (e.g., Hyland, 2007), it is arguable that the local grammar approach discussed here could be applied to the teaching of discourse acts in other disciplines as well.

Before turning to the conclusion section of this paper, we must note that the use of student writers' and expert writers' texts as the data for comparison is not without limitations. For example, student writers' writing, in this case Chinese English-major MA students' degree dissertations in Linguistics, is stylistically different from that of expert writers' published research articles (e.g., dissertations are longer and less densely written; they are written for different purposes and have a different readership). Meanwhile, this study has not considered the linguacultural backgrounds of expert writers either. These may as well account for the differences in their language use. In addition, it is worth mentioning that current developments in other areas of research in Applied Linguistics such as multilingualism (e.g., García, Johnson, Seltzer, & Valdés, 2017; Otheguy, García, & Reid, 2019), Global Englishes (e.g., Galloway & Numajiri, 2020; Smidt, Chau, Rinehimer, & Leever, 2021) and learner corpus research (e.g., Man & Chau, 2019; Man, Lee, Chau, & Smidt, 2021) have highlighted the importance of reconsidering our conceptualization of students no longer as deficient learners but as respectable language users in their own right. Thus, future research will also need to consider how a different take on student writers' language (e.g., to be studied in its own right and based on an internal comparison via a longitudinal design) might potentially contribute to a different set of findings and meaningfully inform EAP writing research and pedagogy.

6. Conclusion

This study presented a local grammar based contrastive investigation into Chinese English-major MA student writers' and expert writers' pragmatic performance of exemplification in academic writing. The investigation shows that while the student writers perform well the function of exemplification in specifying or clarifying abstract superordinate categories, they appear to use the function of exemplification in supporting or illustrating arguments or viewpoints significantly less frequently than expert writers do. In terms of the strategies for exemplification, the student writers underuse performative verbs, exemplificatory imperatives, and the strategy of exemplifying by citing relevant studies, all of which may be attributable to their relative communicative experience in using exemplifications. These observations have implications for EAP writing research and pedagogy. We highlighted in particular the importance of further investigation into academic writers' pragmatic performance of other discourse acts in EAP writing research and the necessity of teaching discourse acts in EAP pedagogy.

Methodologically, the study has shown that local grammars are useful for exploring academic writers' pragmatic performance of discourse acts in EAP writing research, thereby offering a viable method for future investigation into the pragmatic dimension of academic discourse. Moreover, the findings of such research could have potential implications for EAP teaching, as discussed above. Our overall argument, then, is that local grammar based investigation into academic discourse deserves more attention in, and could contribute to, EAP writing research and pedagogy.

Author contributions

Hang Su: Conceptualization; Data analysis; Funding acquisition; Methodology; Project administration; Writing – original draft; Writing – review & editing. **Yuqing Zhang:** Data analysis; Writing – review & editing. **Meng Huat Chau:** Data analysis; Writing – review & editing.

Funding

Hang Su received financial support from the China National Social Science Foundation (Grant No. 19CYY044).

Author statement

We hereby state that this paper has not been submitted for publication in any other journals.

Declaration of competing interest

None.

Acknowledgement

We thank the reviewers for their constructive comments on earlier versions of this paper. We also thank Dr. Jian Xu and Ms. Ming Wu (both at Sichuan International Studies University, China) for their help on statistics.

Appendix. Patterns with relatively low frequency in both corpora

No.	Pattern	CORA		CEMAD	
		Raw	Normed	Raw	Normed
PA 20	Researcher – Hinge – Indicator – Exemplified – Exemplification-SC e.g., *We can illustrate the first point using two classes of example.*	8	1.90	4	1.12
PA 21	Researcher – Indicator – Exemplified e.g., *We will illustrate the main effects and second the interactions.*	7	1.66	6	1.69
PA 22	Initiator – Exemplified – Hinge – Indicator – Exemplification-RS e.g., *For additional discussion of subcategorization frames, see,* e.g., *Hunston and Francis 1999.*	7	1.66	0	0.00
PA 23	Exemplified – Hinge – Exemplification-RS – Indicator e.g., *It is clear that certain learner errors are the same in first and second language acquisition (*cf. *Dulay and Burt 1974; for example).*	5	1.19	0	0.00
PA 24	Exemplified – Indicator – Hinge – Exemplification-RS e.g., *It seems likely to us, that, given the psycholinguistic realities (multi-competence,* e.g. *see Cook 2002) as the sensitivity of measuring instruments increases …*	5	1.19	0	0.00
PA 25	Researcher – Hinge – Indicator – Exemplified e.g., *We then draw specific attention to practices of writing and turn to an example of contemporary writing on the web.*	4	0.95	0	0.00
PA 26	Initiator – Indicator – Exemplification-RS e.g., *As has often been pointed out (*e.g. *Davies 1999) up to the mid-1980s applied linguistics was most closely associated with its educational branch …*	4	0.95	0	0.00
PA 27	Initiator – Indicator – Exemplification-RS – Supporting Statement e.g., *It should be mentioned that, for example, Verhallen and Schoonen (1993) also carried out a statistical analysis …*	4	0.95	0	0.00
PA 28	Exemplification-RS – Hinge – Indicator – Exemplified e.g., *Robinson (1996) serves as an example of the second …*	3	0.71	1	0.28
PA 29	Exemplified – Exemplification-RS – indicator e.g., *It is shown that the creativity of hip–hop language may equally well be conceived in terms of divergent newness (Alim 2006; for example.)*	2	0.47	0	0.00
PA 30	Exemplified – Indicator – Hinge – Exemplification-SC e.g., *Note also that the negative assessment is done without any delay, mitigation (for example, see stress and pitch raise in 'wrong').*	2	0.47	0	0.00
PA 31	Exemplification-SC – Researcher – Hinge – Indicator – Exemplified e.g., *In (27), we also have an instance of Delay (of course yeah I know well) in addition to Added support …*	2	0.47	0	0.00
PA 32	Indicator – Exemplified – Exemplification-SC e.g., *An example of part of speech: The achieve of, the mastery of the thing.*	2	0.47	1	0.28
PA 33	Initiator – Indicator – Exemplified – Exemplification-RS e.g., *As an example of the former, Moore* et al. *(2008) applied a categorization scheme to 974 articles on Islam in the British press …*	2	0.47	0	0.00
PA 34	Initiator – Exemplification-RS – Indicator – Exemplified e.g., *See Moerman 1988, for an example of a conversation analytic study that uses membership knowledge …*	2	0.47	0	0.00
PA 35	Exemplified – Hinge – Researcher – Indicator – Exemplification-SC e.g., *The concept of 'face' also has a quite difference as we illustrated above.*	0	0.00	1	0.28
PA 36	Researcher – Indicator – Exemplification-SC – Exemplified e.g., *I will illustrate with examples how each strategy is employed.*	0	0.00	1	0.28
PA 37	Initiator – Indicator – Exemplification-SC – Exemplified e.g., *As it is illustrated in the following figure, the human body can stand and walk.*	0	0.00	1	0.28
PA 38	Indicator – Exemplification-RS – Exemplified e.g., *As illustrated by Dirk Geeraerts (2008), the three fundamental sociosemantic forces are basic ones in terms …*	0	0.00	1	0.28
PA 39	Researcher – Hinge – Exemplification-RS – Indicator – Exemplified e.g., *I want to mention Ioup* et al.*'s (1994) study as an example of an investigation in which …*	0	0.00	1	0.28

References

Ädel, A. (2006). *Metadiscourse in L1 and L2 English*. Amsterdam: John Benjamins.

Alangari, M., Jaworska, S., & Laws, J. (2020). Who's afraid of phrasal verbs? The use of phrasal verbs in expert academic writing in the discipline of linguistics. *Journal of English for Academic Purposes, 43*, 1–13.

Ansarifar, A., Shahriari, H., & Pishghadam, R. (2018). Phrasal complexity in academic writing: A comparison of abstracts written by graduate students and expert writers in applied linguistics. *Journal of English for Academic Purposes, 31*, 58–71.

Barnbrook, G. (2002). *Defining language: A local grammar of definition sentences*. Amsterdam: John Benjamins.

Barnbrook, G., & Sinclair, J. (2001). Specialized corpus, local and functional grammars. In M. Ghadessy, A. Henry, & R. L. Roseberry (Eds.), *Small corpus studies and ELT: Theory and practice* (pp. 237–276). Amsterdam: John Benjamins.

Bednarek, M. (2007). Local grammar and register variation: Explorations in broadsheet and tabloid newspaper discourse. *Empirical Language Research, 1*(1), 1–20.

Bednarek, M. (2008). *Emotion talk across corpora*. New York: Palgrave Macmillan.

Butler, C. S. (2004). Corpus studies and functional linguistics theories. *Functions of Language, 11*(2), 147–186.

Cheng, W., & Ching, T. (2018). Not a guarantee of future performance": The local grammar of disclaimers. *Applied Linguistics, 39*(3), 263–301.

Coltier, D. (1988). Introduction et gestion des exemples dans les textes à thèse. *Pratiques, 58*, 23–41.

Cortes, V. (2004). Lexical bundles in published and student disciplinary writing: Examples from history and biology. *English for Specific Purposes, 23*, 397–423.

Cortes, V. (2013). The purpose of this study is to": Connecting lexical bundles and moves in research article introductions. *Journal of English for Academic Purposes, 12*, 33–43.

Crossley, S., Kyle, K., & McNamara, D. S. (2016). The development and use of cohesion devices in L2 writing and their relations to judgements of essay quality. *Journal of Second Language Writing, 36*, 1–36.

De Cock, S. (2003). *Recurrent sequences of words in native speaker and advanced learner spoken and written English: A corpus-driven approach*. PhD dissertation. Louvain-la-Neuve: Université catholique de Louvain.

Ellis, N. C., & Wulff, S. (2020). Usage-based approaches to L2 acquisition. In B. VanPatten, G. D. Keating, & S. Wulff (Eds.), *Theories in second language acquisition: An introduction* (pp. 63–82). New York & London: Routledge.

Fang, Z. H. (2021). *Demystifying academic writing: Genres, moves, skills, and strategies*. New York & London: Routledge.

Flowerdew, J. (2006). Use of signalling nouns in a learner corpus. *International Journal of Corpus Linguistics, 11*(3), 345–362.

Flowerdew, J. (2010). Use of signalling nouns across L1 and L2 writer corpora. *International Journal of Corpus Linguistics, 15*(1), 36–55.

Galloway, N., & Numajiri, T. (2020). Global Englishes language teaching: Bottom-up curriculum implementation. *Tesol Quarterly, 54*(1), 118–145.

García, O., Johnson, S. I., Seltzer, K., & Valdés, G. (2017). *The translanguaging classroom: Leveraging student bilingualism for learning*. Philadelphia, PA: Caslon.

Hardie, A. (2014). Log Ratio: An informal introduction. Available at: http://cass.lancs.ac.uk/log-ratio-an-informal-introduction.

Hinkel, E. (2004). *Teaching academic ESL writing: Practical techniques in vocabulary and grammar*. Mahwah, NJ: Lawrence Erlbaum Associates.

Hunston, S. (2002a). Pattern grammar, language teaching, and linguistic variation: Applications of a corpus-driven grammar. In R. Reppen, S. Fitzmaurice, & D. Biber (Eds.), *Using corpora to explore linguistic variation* (pp. 167–183). Amsterdam: John Benjamins.

Hunston, S. (2002b). *Corpora in applied linguistics*. Cambridge: Cambridge University Press.

Hunston, S., & Sinclair, J. (2000). A local grammar of evaluation. In S. Hunston, & G. Thompson (Eds.), *Evaluation in text: Authorial stance and the construction of discourse* (pp. 74–101). Oxford: Oxford University Press.

Hunston, S., & Su, H. (2019). Patterns, constructions and local grammar: A case study of 'evaluation. *Applied Linguistics, 40*(4), 567–593.

Hyland, K. (2004). Disciplinary interactions: Metadiscourse in L2 postgraduate writing. *Journal of Second Language Writing, 13*(2), 133–151.

Hyland, K. (2007). Applying a gloss: Exemplifying and reformulating in academic discourse. *Applied Linguistics, 28*(2), 266–285.

Hyland, K. (2008). As can be seen: Lexical bundles and disciplinary variation. *English for Specific Purposes, 27*(1), 4–21.

Jordan, R. R. (1980). *Academic writing course* (1st ed.). London: Collins.

Jordan, R. R. (1999). *Academic writing course: Study skills in English* (3rd ed.). Harlow: Longman.

Kilgarriff, A., Rychly, P., Smrz, P., & Tugwell, D. (2004). The Sketch engine. In G. Williams, & S. Vessier (Eds.), *Proceedings of the 11th EURALEX international congress* (pp. 105–116). Lorient: Université de Bretagne Sud.

Kirszner, L., & Mandell, S. R. (2017). *Patterns for college writing: A rhetorical reader and guide* (14th ed.). Boston/New York: Bedford/st Martin's.

Larsson, T. (2016). The introductory *it* pattern: Variability explored in learner and expert writing. *Journal of English for Academic Purposes, 22*, 64–79.

Le, T. N. P., & Harrington, M. (2015). Phraseology used to comment on results in the Discussion section of applied linguistics quantitative research articles. *English for Specific Purposes, 39*, 45–61.

Lu, X. (2010). Automatic analysis of syntactic complexity in second language writing. *International Journal of Corpus Linguistics, 15*(4), 474–496. https://doi.org/10.1075/ijcl.15.4.02lu

Lu, X. F., Casal, J. E., & Liu, Y. Y. (2020). The rhetorical functions of syntactically complex sentences in social science research article introductions. *Journal of English for Academic Purposes, 44*, 1–16.

Lu, X. F., Yoon, J., & Kisselev, O. (2021). Matching phrase-frames to rhetorical moves in social science research article introductions. *English for Specific Purposes, 61*, 63–83.

Man, D., & Chau, M. H. (2019). Learning to evaluate through *that*-clauses: Evidence from a longitudinal learner corpus. *Journal of English for Academic Purposes, 37*, 22–33.

Man, D., Lee, K. Y., Chau, M. H., & Smidt, E. (2021). Learning to evaluate through *that*-clauses: Insights from a longitudinal corpus study of Bruneian students' writing. *International Journal of Computer-Assisted Language Learning and Teaching, 11*(2), 84–97.

Moreno, A. I., & Swales, J. M. (2018). Strengthening move analysis methodology towards bridging function-form gap. *English for Specific Purposes, 50*, 40–63.

Oliveira, A. W., & Brown, A. O. (2016). Exemplification in science instruction: Teaching and learning through examples. *Journal of Research in Science Teaching, 53*(5), 737–767.

Ortega, L. (2015). Syntactic complexity in L2 writing: Progress and expansion. *Journal of Second Language Writing, 29*, 82–94.

Otheguy, R., García, O., & Reid, W. (2019). A translanguaging view of the linguistic system of bilinguals. *Applied Linguistics Review, 10*(4), 625–651.

Paquot, M. (2008). Exemplification in learner writing: A cross-linguistic perspective. In F. Meunier, & S. Granger (Eds.), *Phraseology in foreign language learning and teaching* (pp. 101–119). Amsterdam: John Benjamins.

Paquot, M. (2010). *Academic vocabulary in learner writing: From extraction to analysis*. London: Continuum.

Siepmann, D. (2005). *Discourse markers across languages: A contrastive study of second-level discourse markers in native and non-native text with implications for general and pedagogic lexicography*. London & New York: Routledge.

Smidt, E., Chau, M. H., Rinehimer, E., & Leever, P. (2021). Exploring engagement of users of Global Englishes in a community of inquiry. *System, 98*, 1–16.

Su, H. (2017). Local grammars of speech acts: An exploratory study. *Journal of Pragmatics, 111*, 72–83.

Su, H. (2020a). Local grammars and diachronic speech act analysis: A case study of apology in the history of American English. *Journal of Historical Pragmatics, 21*(1), 109–136.

Su, H. (2020b). Patterns, local grammars, and the design of English teaching materials. *ELT Journal, 74*(1), 73–82.

Su, H. (2021). Changing patterns of apology in spoken British English: A local grammar based diachronic investigation. *Pragmatics & Society, 12*(3), 412–438.

Su, H., & Wei, N. X. (2018). *I'm really sorry about what I said"*: A local grammar of apology. *Pragmatics, 28*(3), 439–462.

Su, H., & Zhang, L. (2020). Local grammars and discourse acts in academic writing: A case study of exemplification in linguistics research articles. *Journal of English for Academic Purposes, 43*, 1–11.

Su, H., Zhang, Y. Q., & Lu, X. F. (2021). Applying local grammars to the diachronic investigation of discourse acts in academic writing: The case of exemplification in Linguistics research articles. *English for Specific Purposes, 63*, 120–133.

Todd, R. W., Thienpermpool, P., & Keyuravong, S. (2004). Measuring the coherence of writing using topic-based analysis. *Assessing Writing, 9*(2), 85–104.
Triki, N. (2021). Exemplification in research articles: Structural, semantic and metadiscursive properties across disciplines. *Journal of English for Academic Purposes, 54*, 1–13.
Widdowson, H. G., & Allen, J. P. B. (1985). Teaching the communicative use of English. In J. Swales (Ed.), *Episodes in ESP: A source and reference book on the development of English for science and technology* (pp. 69–89). Oxford: Pergamon Press.
Zhang, L., & Su, H. (2021). Applying local grammars in EAP teaching. *Journal of English for Academic Purposes, 51*, 1–7.

Hang Su is a professor of Foreign Languages and Applied Linguistics at Sichuan International Studies University, China. His research interests include corpus linguistics, (corpus) pragmatics, and applied linguistics. His publications have appeared in *Applied Linguistics*, *ELT Journal*, *Journal of English for Academic Purposes*, *English for Specific Purposes*, *Pragmatics*, and many others.

Yuqing Zhang is an MA student at Sichuan International Studies University, China. Her research interests are corpus linguistics and academic writing, and she has been working as a research assistant on the project 'Local Grammars and Academic Discourse Analysis'.

Meng Huat Chau teaches and mentors students conducting research in Applied Linguistics at Universiti Malaya, Malaysia. His areas of research are corpus linguistics and educational linguistics, spanning learner corpus research, SLA, Global Englishes, multilingualism and language education with a focus on student and teacher agency. His more recent research and writing consider the contribution of Applied Linguistics towards a sustainable world.